

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a newspaper article:

Struggling with debt

Hong Kong university students and those enrolled in other forms of tertiary institutions are having a hard time struggling with huge debts, a recent survey suggests. University students borrow, on average, HK\$109,000 in government loans, while students taking sub-degree and private degree courses borrow HK\$192,000.

The survey involving 727 students who have unpaid loans was carried out from late August to mid-September by the Hong Kong Federation of Youth Groups (HKFYG). About 65 percent of students have taken up at least one part-time job over the past year, working for an average of 33.8 hours per week. Just about 10 percent of students said they were confident about paying off their debt on time, while most expect they would still be repaying well into their 30s.

The most expensive fees are for private degrees, which can cost as much as HK\$90,000 a year. Student loans have an annual interest rate of 1.4 percent, which must be repaid within 15 years after the student graduates. Asked whether they thought they faced financial pressure, students gave an average rating of 7.31 out of a scale of 10, with 10 being "intense pressure".

Amy Fung Dun-mi, Vice-President of HKFYG, suggests the government should get rid of interest rates and subsidise more degree places, while private institutions should offer more scholarships.

You are going to write a letter to a local newspaper to express your concerns regarding the financial problems tertiary students face. You may want to talk about:

- expenses tertiary students face
- the problems of having a loan
- whether getting a degree is worth the cost
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you lend money to your friends?
2. Would you work part time if you were studying at university?
3. Would you consider applying for loans to further your studies?
4. Should students work and save money before going to university?
5. Should parents pay for their children's post-secondary education?
6. Is it better to study a part-time course if you don't have enough money?
7. Should university education be free?
8. Does cost affect your choice of subject to study?